

James P. Foley
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SUMMARY

Versatile, innovative engineering writer with eighteen years of experience writing mostly for developers, at companies including Meta, Google, Disney, Reuters, E-Trade, and Dolby Labs. Documented AR/VR, self-driving cars, APIs, big data, cloud computing, security, and more. Speaks fluent engineer. Enjoys difficult puzzles, elegant solutions, and complex subjects. Interested in a traditional writing role or a chance to use background in philosophy, psychology, fiction, and systems thinking in an emerging role, such as model writing (RLHF), content design, or character design.

TECHNICAL BACKGROUND

Experience has included the following:

- **Languages** (light/moderate experience): Python, JavaScript, Java, Apps Script, C++, Go, PHP, SQL
- **Dev environments**: Visual Studio, Android Studio, Eclipse, Git, Perforce, Jira, CI/CD
- **APIs** including: Google Cloud, Maps, and Drive, Reuters news & financials, E-Trade, and Zuora subscription billing
- **Hardware** including: Arduino, Raspberry Pi, and SOC programming; hardware layer (HAL); sensors, custom boards, Altium
- **Web/CMS tools**: XML, HTML, Markdown; Apache, IIS; WordPress, Drupal, Joomla, Sites, Confluence, SharePoint, Alfresco
- **Doc tools**: DITA, XMLSpy, oXygen, DocBook, Doxygen, Javadoc, FrameMaker, RoboHelp, docs-as-code
- **Office**: Google Apps (with scripting), Microsoft Office (with macros/VBA); advanced skills in spreadsheets, slides, diagrams
- **Graphics**: Figma, Visio, Lucidchart, Gliffy, Blender, Photoshop, GIMP, Inkscape (Illustrator), Tableau, Graphviz
- **Research**: Used LLMs and NotebookLM to help research & review an ambitious science-history book project

EXPERIENCE

RESEARCHER & AUTHOR

JUL 2022 – DEC 2025

- Took on a research & information architecture challenge: research and design a readable modern look at William James, the father of American psychology, and his dense 1902 psychology/philosophy classic *The Varieties of Religious Experience*.
- Wrote and published a unique *Varieties* visual study guide, available on [Amazon](#). Currently polishing a book draft on *Varieties*, its historical context, the arc of James's life & major works, and his continuing influence on philosophy, psychology, and spirituality in the age of modern neuroscience.

SENIOR DOCUMENTATION ENGINEER, FACEBOOK / META

JUL 2017 – JUN 2022

- Sole writer in a core Ads eng team, documenting the Ads code library that's regularly modified by many teams in Facebook, Messenger, Instagram, & WhatsApp. Wrote dev docs, managed wikis, proposed & executed 6-month doc plans.
- Trained engineers & writers on writing & information architecture via one-on-ones, live talks, & training videos.
- Designed the onboarding course catalog for incoming tech writers for the larger Engineering doc team.
- Used in-house SQL tools to build documentation metrics & dashboards, plus a customizable graphic org chart.
- Constant, extensive cross-functional communication and collaboration
- During the company name change to Meta, I won the contest for a new term for Facebookers. "Metamates" was chosen by Mark Zuckerberg based on my internal post about an email exchange with the Pulitzer-winning computer scientist Douglas Hofstadter, who suggested the term because "meta" and "mate" are anagrams.

CONTRACT TECH WRITER, DOLBY LABS

APR 2017 – JUN 2017

- Updated & clarified the Dolby Vision connectivity guide and other docs for TV makers, writing in a DITA environment to strict in-house standards. Was offered a full-time role, but joined Facebook after completing the three-month contract.

CONSECUTIVE CONTRACTS AT GOOGLE CLOUD / ATAP / X LAB / WAYMO

APR 2014 – MAR 2017

- **Google X Lab (2016)**: Documented the autonomous driving tech that became Waymo, including simulators, algorithms, sensors, car systems, and machine learning.
- **ATAP Lab (2015)**: In Google's Advanced Technologies and Projects lab, documented Project Tango, a 6-degrees-of-freedom SLAM platform for Android with uses in AR/VR, mobile devices, and more. Documented Tango concepts, Hardware Abstraction Layer (HAL), and device certification specs for Android device makers. When a case of Ebola arrived

in the US, was appointed to a three-person team that created, documented, and delivered a mobile Ebola-tracking app to the State of Texas within a week. Used Altium to document a prototype electronic device. Contributed to and documented the XDM extended graphic-file spec. Authored or expanded Wikipedia articles on ATAP, Tango, and XDM.

- **Google Cloud Platform (2014):** Wrote user docs and sample code (Java, Python, & Go) for Google's cloud platform, including App Engine and Compute Engine, at developers.google.com.

CONTRACT TECHNICAL WRITER, VARIOUS OTHER CLIENTS

AUG 2011 – MAR 2014

Clients during this period were all in Silicon Valley, except Biomedical Systems in St. Louis. Clients/projects included:

- **Disney Interactive:** Documented multiple big data pipelines including acquisition, ETL, and tools for all Disney games (mobile, social, web, console).
- **Zuora:** Documented REST and SOAP APIs plus Salesforce/Apex tools for a leading cloud-based platform for subscription billing. Replaced two exiting writers as sole writer for this high-growth startup for 7 months, keeping up with 50 developers on an aggressive Agile development cycle, responsible for biweekly release notes and 800 pages of docs in a MindTouch CMS at knowledgecenter.zuora.com.
- **E-Trade:** Rewrote E-Trade's public developer docs (developer.etrade.com), including REST API & Java/C++/PHP SDKs.
- **MoboTap:** Wrote/edited Java dev guides for this startup's PhoneGap (Cordova) API for Dolphin mobile browser.
- **Concurrent, Inc.:** Updated this startup's user guide for Cascading 2.0, a Java API for Hadoop cluster computing.
- **Authentic8:** Wrote early admin content for this early-stage security startup's ultra-secure cloud-based web browser.
- **Biomedical Systems, Inc.:** (St. Louis) Wrote design & user docs per FDA rules for a .NET pharmaceutical-studies website.

TECHNICAL WRITER, THOMSON REUTERS, ST. LOUIS

APR 2003 – JUN 2011

- First formal tech-writing job was at this international news and market-info company where, as part of a writing team, wrote developer, admin, and user docs for the end-to-end Reuters system: backend servers, distribution network, caching, security, APIs, and desktop, web, and mobile apps.
- Also created executive presentations and whitepapers, tested software, and developed diagrams to internally communicate concepts and plans to a large international team of developers.

OTHER PAST ROLES

Before tech writing, had roles in IT, tech support, and technical training. Also worked as the computer science tutor for the University of Missouri Athletic Department and did freelance programming for the University and several business clients.

EDUCATION

University of Missouri, coursework in Anthropological Linguistics and Computer Science

SAMPLES

Sample docs, code, and more at <https://jimfoley.net>, including:

- Sample app plus sample API docs, whitepaper, diagrams, admin guide, and user docs
- Medium articles on the cognitive science of readability, translatability, and writing for ESL or dyslexic readers
- Innovative poster-sized visual study guide on William James's *The Varieties of Religious Experience* (at Amazon)
- Award-winning novelette *Sacred Cows*, listed in *Gizmodo* (*io9.com*) as one of the best sci-fi stories of 2015

REFERENCES

- See recommendations at LinkedIn
- Further references available on request